CLASS OF '26



RASIKH SALAM DAR, *26*

Royal Challengers Bengaluru

Despite the presence of Josh Hazelwood and Bhuvneshar Kumar in the line-up, Dar emerged as the star bowler for the champs in the final, with a haul of 3 for 27. It has been a long, fraught journey for the lad from Kulgam in J&K, which included injuries and a two-year ban due to a faulty birth certificate. With 19 wickets in 12 matches and an economy rate of 9.40, Dar was the leading wicket-taker among uncapped players.

—Suhani Singh



SAKIB HUSSAIN, *21*

Sunrisers Hyderabad

The 2026 IPL season marked the arrival of another promising fast bowler. In 11 matches for SRH, the right-arm pacer from Gopalganj, Bihar, claimed 15 wickets at an average of 26.47, with best figures of 4-24. Significantly, 19 of his 42 overs were bowled at the death. Coming from a modest family, Sakib's mother is said to have sold her jewellery to fund his cricket.

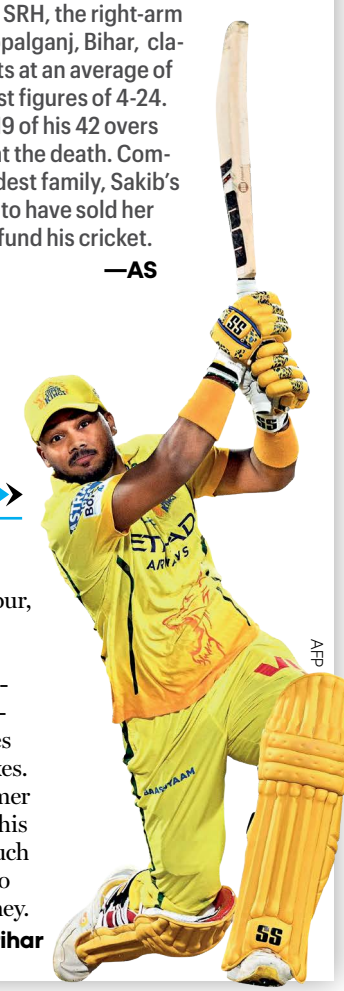
—AS



PRINCE YADAV, *24*

Lucknow Super Giants

It was a season to forget for LSG, but if there was a bright spark, it was the right-arm pacer from Najafgarh, Delhi. Bowling in the power play is no easy feat, but Yadav stepped up, troubling many an opener, including Virat Kohli. His 16 wickets (S/R: 19.50) and economy of 8.83 clearly caught the eyes of the selectors, who rewarded him with a call-up against Afghanistan. **—SS**



KARTIK SHARMA *20*

Chennai Super Kings

The wicketkeeper-bat from Bharatpur, Rajasthan, became an overnight sensation when CSK shelled out Rs 14.2-crore for him at the 2026 auction. The power-hitter did not disappoint. He scored 295 runs in 11 matches at an average of 32.8 and struck 16 sixes. Kartik's father, Manoj Sharma, a former cricketer himself, invested heavily in his son's dream. The family endured much hardship, even taking loans to support the cricketing journey.

—Rohit Parihar

Photographs ANI

AFP

Ojha describes Vaibhav as fearless, the sort a coach remembers with pleasure and exhaustion in equal measure. "Vaibhav was never the one to merely block the ball," he recalls. "This was not because he lacked defensive technique. His mindset was always centred around run-making. Every delivery had scoring potential. With Vaibhav, I realised very early that the challenge was not to curb his aggression, but to shape it intelligently, give it greater control."

Inside the Sooryavanshi household, one cricketer towers above all others in imagination and influence: Brian Lara. Sanjeev introduced Vaibhav to Lara's batting very early, and the boy is said to have watched countless videos of the left-handed West Indies legend. Sanjeev encouraged that fascination, allowing Lara's style to quietly shape the foundations of Vaibhav's batting personality. The influence is clearly visible in his game—the exaggerated backlift, the free strokeplay, the audacity against fast bowling and the instinct to dominate.

Ojha worked particularly hard on strengthening the boy's "punches" through the offside and off the back foot, with emphasis on generating force through the bottom hand. The coach drew inspiration from the methods of Viv Richards and Gordon Greenidge, teaching Vaibhav how to transfer momentum through the left hand at the instant of impact so that the ball exploded through the infield. That technical backbone— at once classical and modern—stands out in Vaibhav's batting today. The backlift rises high, with the wrists cocked so severely the bat seems to load like a catapult. At the top of the movement, the blade often travels laterally while the front